GADS7331 POE Part 3 - External Community Engagement, Feedback, and Refinement

PROOF OF ATTENDANCE & REFLECTION REPORT

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1 Introduction

The following document provides evidence of my attendance and participation in the Joburg Gamedev Meetup held at the Goethe-Institut and includes a description of the event and rationale for its selection, an identification of the individuals who provided feedback, as well as detailed notes from attendee playtesting sessions.

Additionally, the document presents a comprehensive reflection report covering ethical and professional considerations, collaboration with AI, feedback integration, and professional engagement. The report concludes with key insights gained from the experience and their implications for future work in AI-augmented game development.

2 Evidence of Attendance and Engagement

2.1 Proof of Attendance

2.2 Event Description

On the 11th of June, I attended the *Joburg GameDev Meetup*, a vibrant community event hosted at the Goethe-Institut. The gathering fostered an energetic and supportive atmosphere, with indie developers, students, and hobbyists showcasing their projects for playtesting in a dedicated hall. The programme included informative presentations on upcoming events such as a campus game jam and a Pretoria meetup, community Discord groups, industry partnerships, employment opportunities, and practical Unity optimisation techniques. This was then followed by a 30-second pitchathon, after which attendees engaged with the presented games and provided feedback. Networking was further facilitated through refreshments and informal discussions. This event was selected as it offered an ideal environment for connecting with programmers, artists, designers, and indie developer companies, while providing valuable opportunities to playtest my project and obtain constructive industry feedback and insights.

2.3 Feedback Providers

Feedback was provided by two key individuals. The first was a professional programmer and director of a digital solutions company, with expertise in JavaScript, HTML, security systems, and a strong interest in AI applications. The second was a game developer from 24Bit Games and the company's representative at the event as it is one of the sponsors for the *Joburg GameDev Meetup*.

These industry professionals offered practical insights drawn from their technical and development experience.

2.4 Notes of Feedback from Attendees

Feedback was received from two attendees during the playtesting session and the following suggestions were documented:

- First Attendee:
    - Incorporate sprint functionality using the Shift key.
    - Use the Enter key to advance to the next dialogue line instead of clicking the button with the mouse.
    - Optimise the AI implementation, as using Ollama may be overkill for its role in the game. Suggested leveraging virtual GPU resources, since the GPU is already being used for scene rendering and text generation.

- Second Attendee:
    - The player felt too short, with scaling issues noticeable in the first room (ship hangar).
    - Use the Enter key to advance dialogue text instead of clicking with the mouse.
    - Use the Enter key to send player input to the AI instead of clicking the button with the mouse.
    - Make AI response text appear faster on screen.
    - Provide clearer (but not overly obvious) directional guidance at the start of the game, as the player was unsure where to go upon entering the hangar.
    - Make the first puzzle more obvious (e.g., placing one working power cell in the slot) so players quickly learn basic controls and mechanics when moving to the next room.
    - Clearly communicate at the start how to interact with objects.
    - Keep the AI response UI always visible in the corner of the screen. Allow players to use the Tab key to open the input field when needed, which would help forgetful players.
    - Adjust the collider on the power cell slots to improve the snapping mechanic and reduce player frustration.
    - Prevent the E key (interaction) from triggering when the player is typing a response to the AI near an interactable object.
    - Add a subtle wall on the right side of the power cell cupboard to help guide players toward that area without being too obvious.

3 Reflection Report

3.1 Ethical and Professional Considerations

In preparing to attend the Joburg Gamedev Meetup, I proactively emailed the organizing team a week in advance to inform them that I would be playtesting my game as part of a university project. This ensured respectful engagement and aligned with professional norms of transparency.

During the 30-second pitchathon and playtesting sessions, I clearly stated that AI tools assisted with coding and that the game's core mechanic relies on a locally run large language model (LLM) for dynamic, real-time responses. While some attendees initially assumed the dialogue was pre-written, I clarified that responses are AI-generated, adaptive, and context-aware. I also emphasized that the model runs entirely locally, addressing potential concerns about data privacy.

No attendees raised issues regarding ownership, accuracy, or responsible use of LLM outputs. This positive reception reinforced the value of proactive disclosure. In future professional settings, I plan to personally explain the role of AI to every individual playtester, even after group disclosure. This will ensure players fully understand they are interacting with generative AI, allowing more informed engagement and upholding ethical standards in AI-augmented game development.

3.2 Collaboration with AI

External feedback from playtesters significantly shaped my approach to prompt engineering and LLM-driven mechanics. One memorable moment occurred when a playtester asked the in-game LLM, *"How do I play the game?"*. This query was unanticipated. To my surprise, the AI responded by outlining the complete flow of the game – from the first puzzle to the last – effectively providing spoilers. While impressive in coherence, this undermined the intended design that encourages room-by-room exploration and progressive AI consultation.

The interaction prompted reflection on player behaviour. Attendees asked not only narrative questions (such as *"Where can I find the ship's blackbox?"*) but also practical ones about controls (e.g. *"How do I interact with objects?"* or *"How do I drop an object I'm holding?"*). This highlighted the need for the LLM to handle diverse inputs without spoiling exploration. I revisited and refined the system prompt to distinguish question types, ensuring appropriate non-spoiler guidance on controls while remaining in character for narrative assistance. This user-guided iteration strengthened the gameplay mechanics.

3.3 Feedback Integration

Several pieces of feedback proved particularly valuable because they directly addressed usability while preserving the game's core vision of player intuition and AI-assisted discovery. Suggestions for subtle environmental hints were especially impactful. These would help players navigate without overt hand-holding, maintaining the balance of exploration and AI consultation. Playtesters also recommended providing gentle indications of object interaction possibilities and equipping the AI itself to explain basic interactions with the environment. These insights were highly relevant as they aligned with the design goal of using the LLM as a needed guide throughout the game.

Additional practical feedback included standardising the *'Enter'* key for advancing dialogue or submitting text to the AI, which reduces tedium, and improving the power cell slot interaction to prevent player frustration and confusion with snapping mechanics. Discussions around AI optimization and the broader implications of running LLM-based games on players' hardware were also insightful, though time and resource constraints prevented immediate implementation of such feedback to the project.

The received feedback directly influenced my design thinking and technical decisions. It encouraged a more nuanced approach to environmental storytelling and prompted further refinement of the LLM prompt to make it adaptable – balancing helpful progression hints with control explanations. Overall, integrating this input refined the player experience without diluting the innovative AI-driven concept.

3.4 Professional Engagement

Presenting my work publicly at the meetup offered invaluable lessons that broke the tunnel vision often developed during solo development. As the creator, I was thoroughly familiar with every puzzle and path, which led to assumptions about player behaviour that did not always hold. Observing playtesters approach the game with no prior knowledge revealed untested areas and alternative interaction patterns. This highlighted the importance of designing for complete newcomers rather than relying on developer intuition.

The tone and focus of feedback differed markedly from typical academic critique as Discussions were interactive, explorative, and collaborative rather than brief specific or rubric based. Attendees actively experimented with mechanics, shared ideas for testing scenarios, and built upon each another's suggestions. Feedback stemmed from genuine personal experiences with the game – highlighting moments of delight, amusement, confusion, or frustration – rather than checklist-style assessment. This real-world, community-oriented engagement provided experience-based and explorative insights and underscored the value of public playtesting in game development.

4 Conclusion

In conclusion, public playtesting offered multifaceted benefits for this AI-integrated game project. Ethical transparency fostered positive reception, while player feedback refined prompt engineering, environmental design, and interaction mechanics. The collaborative atmosphere expanded my perspective as a developer, emphasising the need to anticipate diverse player approaches.

Moving forward, I am committed to granular disclosure practices and continued prompt iteration to balance guidance with discovery. Ultimately, this process has strengthened both the project and my professional approach to responsible, user-centred game development in an AI-augmented landscape.

[Reflection Report: 800 words]

5 Referencing

Canva, 2026. *GADS7331 POE Part 3 - Proof of Attendance and Reflection Report Cover Page*. [electronic print]. Available at: < https://canva.link/oyxwvm2l0qfj9vf >[Accessed 26 March 2026].

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